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CHICAGO CITY COUNCIL



Ald. Brendan Reilly watches as City Council members argue over a motion during a procedural vote on Mayor Brandon Johnson's 2025 budget at City Hall on Wednesday. **ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Mayor averts showdown over North Side project

Johnson prevails in spat over megadevelopment, aldermanic prerogative

By Alice Yin
Chicago Tribune

Mayor Brandon Johnson and his allies fended off a challenge Wednesday from a City Council opponent over the fate of a controversial megadevelopment project near the stalled Lincoln Yards site, following a heated debate two days before he hopes to pass his 2025 budget. Ultimately, local Ald. Scott Waguespack, 32nd, backed down from his plan to call on the full council to shoot down Sterling Bay's proposed Lincoln Park residential high-rise development at 1840 N. Marcey St.

Johnson's Department of Planning and Development and his handpicked Zoning Committee chair, Ald. Walter Burnett, 27th, both want the project to move forward. But it failed in the committee Monday after Waguespack opposed it, setting up a showdown in City Council chambers Wednesday over aldermanic prerogative, the long tradition of the body following the local alderman's wishes on development matters and other ward issues. The parliamentary spat began when Burnett reported out his committee's items from Monday but did not include the rejection of the Sterling Bay proposal.

Waguespack stood up to object and demand that the committee's "No" vote get approved with the other zoning items, including the upcoming quantum computing site on the Far South Side. Burnett and Johnson argued tacking on the Sterling Bay rejection would mean the entire Zoning Committee report from Monday would need to be voted down as well, which Waguespack disputed. "First of all, it's very untoward and I think it's unethical ... (and) sets a very slippery slope when the chairman does

Turn to Project, Page 2

For monarchs, 'a call to action'

State insect takes a big step closer to protection under Endangered Species Act

By Nara Schoenberg
Chicago Tribune

It's a big day for insects. The U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service announced Tuesday that it is proposing the monarch butterfly for threatened species status under the Endangered Species Act, a big step forward in a process set in motion in 2014 with a petition from conservationists. After a 90-day public comment period, the agency will make a final decision. "Despite its fragility, (the monarch) is remarkably resilient, like many things in nature when we just give them a chance," Fish and Wildlife Service Director Martha Williams said in a written statement. "Science shows that the monarch needs that chance, and this proposed listing invites and builds on unprecedented public participation in shaping monarch conservation efforts." The eastern migratory population of monarchs, which flies through Illinois, is estimated to have declined by approximately 80% since the 1990s.



Monarch butterflies gather at Lighthouse Field State Beach in Santa Cruz, Calif., on Sunday. Federal wildlife officials on Tuesday proposed that monarch butterflies receive protection as a threatened species. **NIC CORY/THE NEW YORK TIMES**

The western migratory population has declined by more than 95% since the 1980s, according to the Fish and Wildlife Service, which said the western populations have a greater than 99% chance of extinction by 2080. With big orange wings veined in black, the monarch butterfly is still a fairly common sight in the Chicago area, a summer breeding ground and a stop on the annual fall migration to Mexico, which

can span up to 3,000 miles. Tuesday's announcement is "a call to action," said Karen Klinger, a geographic information systems analyst at the Field Museum and the lead author of a July study focusing on strategies to maximize monarchs' success in small urban and suburban gardens. "This species is endangered and people

Turn to Monarchs, Page 4

FBI's Wray to step down

A likely target of Trump, he tells staffers he plans to leave at end of Biden's term

By Eric Tucker
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — FBI Director Christopher Wray told the bureau workforce Wednesday that he plans to resign at the end of President Joe Biden's term in January, an announcement that came a week and a half after President-elect Donald Trump said he would nominate loyalist Kash Patel for the job. Wray said at a town hall meeting that he would be stepping down "after weeks of careful thought," three years short of the completion of a 10-year term marked by high-profile and politically charged investigations, including that led to two separate indictments of Trump last year. Wray's intended resignation is not unexpected considering that Trump had settled on Patel to be director and had repeatedly aired his ire at Wray, including in a television interview broadcast Sunday. By stepping down rather than waiting to be fired, Wray is trying to avert a collision with the new Trump administration that he said would have further entangled the FBI "deeper into the fray." "My goal is to keep the focus on our mission — the indispensable work you're doing on behalf of the American people every day," Wray said, adding, "In my view, this is the best way to avoid dragging the bureau deeper into the fray, while reinforcing the values and principles of the FBI."

Turn to Wray, Page 9

MICHAEL MADIGAN TRIAL

Amid fight over his competency, Acevedo must take the stand

By Jason Meisner
and Megan Crepeau
Chicago Tribune

Former Illinois state Rep. Edward Acevedo must testify in the corruption trial of ex-House Speaker Michael Madigan, a federal judge ruled Wednesday, despite strenuous arguments from Acevedo's attorney that he is not competent to take the witness stand. Acevedo, 61, a Chicago Democrat who served on Madigan's leadership team before leaving the legislature in 2017, has been a central figure in the case against Madigan. The ex-speaker is accused of inducing utility giants ComEd and AT&T Illinois to pay Acevedo nearly \$150,000 on consulting contracts for little or no work. Acevedo was granted immunity by the U.S. attorney's office after indicating he'd invoke his constitutional right against self-incrimination. His attorney then objected on health grounds, arguing that Acevedo has been diagnosed with dementia and that his memory issues

Turn to Acevedo, Page 4

A vow to protect immigrants

Gov. JB Pritzker again gave assurances that Illinois would protect immigrants, days after President-elect Donald Trump's "border czar" threatened deportations. **Page 5**

No merger for grocery giants

Albertsons is giving up on its merger with Kroger — and it is suing the chain, saying it didn't do enough to secure regulatory approval for the agreement. **Business, Page 2**

Notebook sheds light on killing

A man charged with killing the CEO of UnitedHealthcare was arrested with a notebook that detailed plans for the shooting, law enforcement officials say. **Nation & World**

TODAY'S WEATHER

COLD

High 18 Low 10

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 12

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
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